

In the Library with broken link
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In 2026, researchers articulate community-focused environmental justice scholarship via topics such as urban pollution burdens, warehouse and data center construction, and historical housing segregation. Addressing questions of historical discrimination and environmental racism crosses many academic disciplinary boundaries and community engagement is an increasingly important part of the expected portfolios of scholars in higher education.

Negotiating this transdisciplinary and community-focused space requires a great deal of labor.

The scholars leading these projects frequently lean on their institution's IT departments and libraries for technical and infrastructure support, including access to licensed software, data management, and web development. Sometimes these collaborations come off without a hitch.

More often, there are many hurdles and negotiations that need to happen to make the sociotechnical systems of higher ed work appropriately in support of a community environmental justice project.

I come to this workshop as an academic library worker in data management and digital scholarship who has years of working as a collaborator with researchers on environmental justice projects in several institutions. I would like to suggest a discussion among peers with similar experiences to discuss how our roles enable us to foreground the social and technical constructions that come with this kind of technology support work in our institutions, and how we might provoke the development of sociotechnical systems in academia that are more responsive to dynamic community engagement and justice.

I have developed a provocation based primarily on my work with two collaborative efforts:

Example case #1 - [SoCal Earth](#)

For several years I have been working with faculty and student colleagues at Pitzer College's Robert Redford Environmental Center in support of their development of the interactive data platforms on the SoCal Earth site. Their exploration of questions of [environmental equity](#) involves the integration of datasets and perspectives from several different sources. While this project benefitted from being relatively well-funded (and able to hire web developers and GIS data managers), the use of the library's consortial ESRI license in new ways, and our administrative support in managing content ownership across several years of student fellow turnover, surfaces some particular sociotechnical problems.

Example case #2 - Remediation and historic preservation of racist housing covenants in San Bernardino.

In coordination with Jennifer Tilton (University of Redlands) and [People's History of the IE](#) project, I have been working on data management and workflow development to preserve the text and geographic data related to racially restrictive housing covenants in San Bernardino County, California. [California's AB 1466 \(2021\)](#) required county recorders of deeds to remove racially restrictive language from property deeds, but also to preserve the text for historical research purposes. However, the mechanisms and workflows of this process are left to each county government to develop. With the wide variety of resources available in the counties of California, not all documentation and data access will be the same. San Bernardino County, for example, is grappling with several years of economic decline and environmental challenges. Jen and I have been meeting with the archivists and GIS specialists of San Bernardino county to develop a process to create an interactive web map of the restrictive subdivisions and an online archive of the original racist deeds. We are fortunate to have a community of practice in the [Mapping Prejudice Project](#) that has provided invaluable guidance. Yet, this is "extra" work for

all of us and we are doing our best to navigate the platforms and systems of our respective workplaces to make a sustainable archive for the San Bernardino community.

Provocation:

The data required to fully document and discuss issues of ECJ requires some skills and access to technology. Licensed products come with restrictions; open-source tools may have a larger learning curve. Our roles as researchers and “support staff” are often similarly circumscribed by a capitalist architecture. How do we negotiate this in support of educating and advocating for justice in our communities?